

IN TEST: 10 CD-ROM DRIVES

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- ROM D R I V E S

Diskography

On your way to buying a CD-ROM drive? Our Test Centre plays the disc jockey and tells what's what to help you make a wise decision

DIGITAL MEDIA RESEARCH AND TEST CENTRE

We've seen the trusty CD-ROM drive grow in terms of importance in a system to such an extent that it now forms an indispensable part of any PC. This has primarily been fuelled by the fact that software—both applications as well as operating systems—have also grown exponentially in terms of install sizes. What was once available on sets of floppy disks as a *de facto* standard, now comes on CD-ROMs. Added to this, the increasing use of multimedia in conventional applications has been a pivotal factor in transforming the CD drive into a component that you can't do without.

Thanks to the Video CD and DivX rage, the popularity of movies on CD-ROM, though illegal, is a big selling point and forms one of the main uses that most home users have for their CD-ROM drive. The importance of the CD drive is also, in fact, corroborated by the fact that

nowadays boot floppies are so rare—you can boot and install operating systems off the CD-ROM drive itself. While other optical standards such as DVD-ROMs have also risen and taken some of the limelight away from the CD-ROM over the past couple of years, the economical price and very high availability of software and working titles have ensured that the CD drive is still widely used, both in new computers as well as standalone purchases.

In terms of technology, however, the underlying operating principles and mechanisms of CD drives have remained largely unchanged. The major advancements that we have seen are the increase in the speeds itself and not the actual read technology.

Looking back, the first conventional CD-ROM drive sported a 4x read speed (that's four times the speed of an audio CD, or 150 KBps x 4 = 600 KBps). Today's fastest CD-ROM drives

